

# The Theology of the Trinity — Volume IV

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## Interreligious Frontiers, Global Contexts, and the Trinity in a World of Creation

*Fourth volume in the study series. Prepared 17 July 2026. All quotations are drawn verbatim from the sources in the source notebook (Emery & Levering, eds., The Oxford Handbook of the Trinity; Kärkkäinen, Christian Understandings of the Trinity; a Brief History of the Doctrine of the Trinity; the Cambridge Companion to the Trinity; Moltmann, The Trinity and the Kingdom; and cited primary texts), with the notebook's internal citations retained.*

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## 1. The Trinity and Judaism

Christian Trinitarianism emerged from within Jewish monotheism: "Both Christians and Jews join in the famous *Shema*... 'Hear, O Israel: The Lord our God, the Lord is one.'" What "became a full-fledged *trinitarian* confession... began... as a more-or-less binitarian understanding of God" — "explicit binitarianism and implicit trinitarianism."

**Two powers / Philo.** Philo of Alexandria posited that "in the one living and true God there were two supreme and primary powers, Goodness... and Authority... and that the third thing which was between the two... was the Logos"; "God and his two Powers are in reality one. To the human mind they appear as a Triad with God above the powers that belong to him."

**Memra / Logos / Wisdom.** In the LXX "the term *logos* (Hebrew *davar*) was used frequently to describe God's utterances," yet "Nowhere in the Old Testament is there any solid evidence that

a sacred writer viewed the Word of Yahweh as a personal being distinct from Yahweh himself." Over time "Jewish thought had already bestowed a hypostatic character on such attributes as the name, the word, and the wisdom of God." "The prologue of the Fourth Gospel... seems to fuse the concept of Hebrew Logos with that of Wisdom."

**Kabbalah, \*zimsum\*, \*Shekinah\*.** Moltmann draws on Isaac Luria: "*Zimsum* really means 'concentration' or 'contraction', a withdrawal into the self." Applied to the Trinity: "a divine self-limitation occurs in the love between the Father and the Son through a 'contraction'... Eternity breathes itself in, so as to breathe out the Spirit of life." On the *Shekinah* (Rosenzweig): "God himself cuts himself off from himself, he gives himself away to his people, he suffers with their sufferings."

**Jewish objections.** *Dialogue with Trypho* — Trypho: "your assertion that this Christ existed as God before the ages... appears to me to be not merely paradoxical, but also foolish." The **Barcelona Disputation (1263)** — Nachmanides "agrees that God is wise, that he wills and is powerful, but insists that these are all attributes of the divine essence and that the doctrine of the Trinity is an erroneous conclusion." **Pinchas Lapide** (with Moltmann, 1978): Jews may read Trinitarianism "as either a heavenly triumvirate or, worse, as *tritheism*"; the incarnation earns the Talmudic term *shittuf*; he "chastises Christians for a want of shyness in their over-boldness to specify God... Trinitarianism inquires too deeply into 'the inscrutable God of the Bible.'"

## 2. The Trinity and Islam

**Qur'anic critique.** The Qur'an protests: "Indeed, the truth deny they who say: 'Behold, God is the third of a trinity' — seeing that there is no deity whatever save the One God." Against a Son: "how could there be a 'son' to Him, there never having been a 'spouse' to Him"; "The heavens would almost break up... at it... they are claiming a son to the Merciful!"

**Muslim objections — \*tawhid\* and \*shirk\*.** For Muslims "God's oneness cannot be reconciled with the Trinity, which for them is nothing else than tritheism," making Christians "associators" guilty of *shirk* — "the only offence that God could never forgive: the denial of God's Uniqueness (*shirk*)." God's inner life is held inaccessible: "God's own internal life is unknown to man." And Islam "will never accept that its Christology is false."

**Christian responses.** **John of Damascus** (under Islamic rule) met the "associators" charge "by taking up the language of the Qur'an which speaks of the 'word and spirit' of God, and arguing that to deny the divinity of the word and spirit of God is to become a 'mutilator' of God," presenting the Trinity "starting from an uncompromising emphasis on the unity of God." **John Paul II**: Christians can explain "that the three Persons of the Godhead do not diminish divine unity but characterize it... The Christian doctrine of the Trinity explicitly rejects any form of tritheism or polytheism." **David Burrell**: the true parallel is not Jesus/Muhammad but

Jesus/Qur'an — "Christians believe that Jesus is the Word of God made human, while Muslims believe the Qur'an to be the Word of God made 'book'" — and the Muslim doctrine of the *uncreated* Qur'an builds "a conceptual bridge to John 1:1."

### 3. Russian Sophiology — Soloviev, Florensky, Bulgakov

**Vladimir Soloviev** (1853–1900), "the father of Russian sophiology," gave the concept *bogochelovechestvo* ("God-manhood, the humanity of God, or divine-humanity") — signifying that "God's being as Trinitarian is always-already an eternal communion with humanity."

**Pavel Florensky** critiqued the Eastern neglect of the Spirit: "'Unnoticed and gradually' a tendency had permeated the Church to speak, rather than of the Holy Spirit, of 'grace', that is, of something already and conclusively impersonal," words that "only slightly if at all have in their sights the personal independent existence of the third hypostasis."

**Sergius Bulgakov** (1871–1944) systematized sophiology. "Sophia is the 'self-revelation of the Holy Trinity'; the Father is 'Divine Depth and Mystery, the Divine Subject of self-revelation,' revealed in the Son and completed by the Spirit — 'the hypostatic love that unites the Father and the Son.'" Crucially, "Sophia is not another *hypostasis*... nor some 'thing' in addition to the *ousia* and *hypostases* of the Trinity"; rather "Sophia is the *ousia* (nature) of God, but the *ousia* of God *as* revealed" — "Divine Sophia is God's exhaustive self-revelation, the fullness of divinity." Sophia "unites God with the world as the one common principle"; "One and the same Sophia is revealed in God and in creation" — the "cosmic *sobornost* of concrete all-unity in divine love." The "Sophia Affair" saw Lossky attack sophiology from a strictly apophatic, essence-energies standpoint.

### 4. The Trinity as Social Programme — Liberation and Political Theology

The nineteenth-century Orthodox thinker **Nicolai Fedorov** "coined the expression 'the Trinity is our social programme.'"

**Leonardo Boff** uses *perichoresis* to present God as an inclusive society, "a model for any just, egalitarian... social organization." Defective images distort society (Father-alone → authoritarianism; Spirit-alone → anarchism); the Triune God demands justice: "a society that takes its inspiration from trinitarian communion cannot tolerate class differences, dominations based on power." "By their practice and theory, capitalist regimes contradict the challenges and invitations of Trinitarian communion." "Human society is a pointer on the road to the mystery of the Trinity."

**Jürgen Moltmann** turns social Trinitarianism against "Christian monotheism," which "provides the justification for earthly domination... a 'holy rule.'" "This doctrine of the Trinity must be developed as the true theological doctrine of freedom" — corresponding to "a community of men and women, without privileges and without subjugation." "The Christian doctrine of the Trinity *compels* us to develop social personalism or personal socialism."

**Black and Hispanic.** James Cone: the blackness of God reveals "a 'beloved triune community' at work in the liberation of the oppressed." US Hispanic theology finds in the Trinity's threefold differentiation "a prophetic alternative" to assimilation.

**Critiques.** **Karen Kilby** warns of projecting "fashionable political concepts onto God." **Kathryn Tanner:** *perichoresis* yields "very vague recommendations." **Miroslav Volf** ("*The Trinity Is Our Social Program?*"): "the road from the doctrine of the Trinity to proposals about global or national social arrangements is long, torturous, and fraught with danger" — Novak and Boff draw opposite (capitalist vs socialist) conclusions from the same doctrine; Trinitarian concepts apply to human community "only in an analogous rather than a univocal sense."

## 5. Ecological Trinitarian Theology, Panentheism, and the Sciences

**Ecology.** **Moltmann:** "I was able to write an ecological doctrine of creation... because I could replace thinking in the language of domination... by a thinking in networks and milieus," recovering "the biblical perspective on nature as the household (*oikos*)... the permanent dwelling place of God." **Ivone Gebara** (ecofeminist): though the Trinity may seem "superfluous... in the light of the anguished cries of so many," she finds its "'trinitarian structure' of oneness as diversity permeates the cosmos."

**Panentheism.** Moltmann advances a "trinitarian panentheism": "God, having created the world, also dwells in it, and conversely the world which he has created exists in him," consummated when "God in the world and the world in God... the glorifying of the world through the Spirit."

**Pannenberg** objects: "the equation of the two means the absorption of the immanent Trinity in the economic Trinity."

**The Spirit in creation.** **Luther** on Gen 1:2: "the Holy Spirit broods. As a hen broods her eggs... it is the office of the Holy Spirit to make alive." **Maximus the Confessor:** "The Holy Spirit is not absent from any created being... providentially permeating all things with His power." **Aquinas:** the Spirit is the "'Life-Giver'... who 'guides and quickens all things created by the Father through the Son.'"

**Sciences.** "Some leading science and theology scholars have... recently shown growing interest in the intersection of the Trinity and... our cosmos." Moltmann integrates evolution: the Spirit as "the principle of creativity," "principle of individuation," and "holistic principle." **Richard**

**Swinburne** (Bayesian): "if there is a God, who is a person, the doctrine of the Trinity is what we should expect." **Paul Davies** treats the laws as a Platonic ground but rejects biblical Trinitarianism.

## 6. The Trinity, Divine Simplicity, and Classical Theism

**Simplicity.** God "is what God is said to 'have.'" **Augustine**: "Our reason for calling the Trinity simple is because it is what it has — with the exception of the real relations in which the Persons stand to each other." **Gregory of Nyssa** rejected Eunomius's equation of simplicity with "ungeneracy." **Aquinas**: "the divine simplicity requires in God that essence be identical with *suppositum*... in God essence is not really distinct from person; and yet the persons are really distinguished from one another. For 'person'... signifies relation as subsisting in the divine nature."

**Attributes.** "God is substance as he is wisdom or is wisdom as he is substance." **Richard of St Victor**: "everything that is found within... true divinity is really, substantially and supremely one." Appropriations then assign the common attributes — power to the Father, wisdom to the Son, goodness to the Spirit.

**Aseity and innascibility.** **Barth**: "The eternal Trinity is distinguished... by the simplicity, perfection and a-seity... of its essence." **Bonaventure** roots the Father in *fontalis plenitudo* and innascibility — "the Father can be conceived of as a person in virtue of his primacy alone." **Aquinas** counters: "Innascibility is a pure negation... we must presuppose some prior, positive understanding of the Father as a principle, and this prior understanding is given in the notion of paternity."

**Classical theism.** "God is absolutely Simple: he is Act, without composition, without movement, and without becoming... God is beyond all change." Hegel turned substance into subject ("one subject — three modes of being"); Moltmann critiques the "monotheistic God... defined simply through his power of disposal," against which "the triune God represents an inexhaustible life... in which they are present with one another, for one another and in one another."

## 7. The Twentieth-Century Renewal of Pneumatology — Congar and Others

**Yves Congar** (*I Believe in the Holy Spirit*) repaired the Christology–pneumatology split: "there can be no Christology without pneumatology and no pneumatology without Christology,"

developing a "pneumatological Christology," and recovering the early charismatic life (the apostles "set out, filled with the assurance of the Holy Spirit").

**Bulgakov:** "The Holy Spirit is the hypostatic love that unites the Father and the Son"; the Son is Truth, the Spirit is Beauty; as "spirit of truth" the Spirit "represents the principle of reality."

**Moltmann:** a reciprocal "pneumatological christology" and "christological doctrine of the Spirit." "Through the powers and potentialities of the Spirit, the Creator indwells the creatures he has made." The Spirit is an active subject: "The Spirit is the glorifying God. The Spirit is the unifying God... a subject from whose activity the Son and the Father receive their glory and their union."

**John Paul II** (*Dominum et Vivificantem*, 1986): the Spirit acted "even before Christ — from the beginning"; "every quest of the human spirit for truth and goodness, and in the last analysis for God, is inspired by the Holy Spirit" — grounding a pneumatological theology of religions.

## 8. Global and Non-Western Trinitarian Theologies

Christianity is now "a predominantly non-Western religion"; "as the Church inculturates globally, there will be other ways of speaking the truth of God's Trinity... that will deepen the understanding of God's mystery." **Miguel Díaz:** "God is not only Greek or Latin, but must also be black, red, Asian, Latin American, and US Hispanic."

**East Asia — Yin-Yang.** **Jung Young Lee** proposes a Trinity of change: "God the Father as 'change itself,' God the Holy Spirit as 'the power of change,' and God the Son as 'the perfect manifestation of change.'" Christ "can be understood as the *Tao* (Way)"; the Spirit as feminine "Mother (Yin)" and *ch'i*, "the vital energy... very much similar to... *ruach* in Hebrew and *pneuma* in Greek." **Heup Young Kim** sees a "decentering [of] Western theology."

**India — \*Saccidananda\*.** Christian encounter first fixed on the *Trimurti* (Brahma, Vishnu, Shiva), but the deeper inculturation came through *Saccidananda* (*sat, cit, ananda*). **Keshab Chunder Sen** correlated Father, Son, Spirit with *sat, cit, ananda* — "the True, the Good, the Beautiful." **Monchanin and Abhishiktananda** (Henri Le Saux) at their *Saccidananda Ashram* prayed to the Father as *sat* (the "principleless Principle"), the Son as *cit* (the "intellectual Image of the Existent"), the Spirit as *ananda*; **Brahmabandhab Upadhyay** drew on Thomism (hymn *Vande Saccidanandam*) to refine Sen's analogy with proper senses of "person" and "nature."

**Buddhism — \*Trikāya\*.** **James Fredericks** finds a parallel in the Mahayana "three bodies of the Buddha" — the formless *Dharmakāya* using "skillful means" (*Sambhogakāya, Nirmānakāya*) out of compassion — a relational ontology helping Christians imagine God "not as a static 'substance,' but as a dynamic, self-emptying movement of love."

**Africa.** Theologians build "employing distinctively African resources, including... the ancestry theme." **Mercy Amba Oduyoye** relates the Trinity "to traditional African life and conceptions of community": "Our baptism into the name of the Trinity means that we should stand not for monarchies and hierarchies but rather for participation."

**Limits.** Inculturation must "test [its] continuity with the Church's Graeco-Latin heritage so that philosophy and culture do not dictate to revelation." "The concept of person does not translate easily into Sanskrit"; cross-cultural Trinitarian mapping "will always fall short of the exactitude that would make it entirely compelling" — yet remains "a necessary and deeply enriching evolution of the doctrine in the third millennium."

*All texts and quotations retrieved verbatim from the notebook's sources with their internal citations preserved. Fourth volume in the study series (main study + Companion + Vol. III + this). The series now spans Scripture, every historical era, the disputed systematic questions, worship, the interreligious frontiers, and the global reception of the doctrine. A consolidated single-volume edition with unified table of contents — and optional PDF — can be assembled on request.*